

financially unsustainable, it's not helping your kids. Study after study has shown that when parents constantly hover over their children, giving them everything they ask for (and plenty of stuff besides), those children grow up to be less-confident adults. They never learn to function independently of their parents; instead of self-sufficiency, they inherit a sense of entitlement, expecting the world to cater to their every whim. I used to find it baffling how so many of my divorced friends' kids displayed a staggering sense of entitlement. Then I realized it was their own guilt-ridden parents who had created the little monsters.

Instead of spoiling your children with iPods and smart phones and laptops, enlist their help. You're working twice as hard to keep the family afloat—they can contribute, too, by completing household chores and other assigned tasks. They should be able to take care of some things themselves, from basic hygiene to homework to keeping their rooms tidy. Each member of the family must learn to pull his or her own weight.

It's a peculiar symptom of modern times that our children have become more infantilized. I can't tell you how many single mothers I've met who are juggling two and three jobs to make ends meet, and their kids can't be bothered to stop playing Xbox games long enough to come and help them put away the groceries they just worked hard to buy. This problem seems to be particularly problematic in North America, where kids enjoy a protracted childhood—so protracted that 30-year-olds think it's okay to move back home. In some cultures, this kind of dependence is simply unacceptable.

Take the Matsigenka people of the Amazon, a tribe of about 12,000 people living in Peru. Matsigenka toddlers use machetes to cut wood for kindling and prepare their own food over an open fire. Six- and seven-year-olds accompany their parents on hunting trips and help prepare meals in the kitchen. By puberty, the children of the Matsigenka have learned essential survival skills. Not only that—they can use their skills to help the whole tribe survive.

It's time you started thinking of your family as a tribe. This is especially true if you're a single parent. Your tribe may be small, but